Workforce scheduling concept questionnaire

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For the ShiftHarbor product research team. Explore how frontline managers currently handle schedule changes and assess a proposed shift-cover service. The concept is hypothetical and has no live availability or promised performance.

Programming brief

Prepared by Elena Park for survey programming. Version 1.0, 12 October 2026. This is a questionnaire specification; routing and programming notes are not respondent-facing text.

Ask applicable closed questions before proceeding. Open text is optional. Display one question per screen, preserve Back navigation and retain earlier answers. If an answer changes, clear only downstream answers that are no longer applicable.

Begin with eligibility and recent behavior. Ask for an unprompted account before showing issue lists or ratings. Put classification questions after the experience questions unless a variable is needed for eligibility.

Show all seven verbal labels on evaluative scales, from the negative pole to the positive pole. Non-evaluative alternatives such as Cannot remember are separate from the numbered scale. Randomize nominal lists where instructed; never randomize an ordinal scale.

At an ineligible route, display: Thank you for your interest. This study is about a different experience. At completion, display: Thank you. Your responses have been recorded.

Respondent introduction

We are researching how managers arrange shift cover. This survey takes about 8 minutes. First, think about the most recent unfilled shift you dealt with in the past three months. Later you will see an idea for a service. It is fine if your last attempt to find cover was unsuccessful. Written comments are optional.

Eligibility

S1. Which best describes your involvement in staff schedules?

I make or approve schedules; I help arrange cover but do not approve schedules; I only view my own schedule; I have no involvement.

Programming: Single answer, fixed order. Continue only for the first two answers. Study recruitment is limited to adults; do not add an age question here.

S2. In the past three months, have you tried to find cover for an unfilled shift?

Yes; No; I cannot remember.

Programming: Single answer. Continue only if Yes. An unsuccessful attempt is eligible.

Current practice

Q1. Thinking about the most recent occasion, how much notice did you have before the shift began?

Less than 4 hours; 4 to less than 12 hours; 12 to less than 24 hours; 1 to 3 days; More than 3 days; I cannot remember.

Programming: Single answer, fixed ordinal order. Keep Cannot remember separate from time bands.

Q2. What happened on that occasion?

[Optional written response]

Programming: Optional text, up to 300 characters. Permit a blank answer. Do not request names, contact details or account numbers. Ask before listing channels or problems.

Q3. Which methods did you use to find cover?

Telephone calls; Individual text messages; Group messaging app; Scheduling software; Email; Agency or staffing partner; Another method [text]; None of these.

Programming: Multiple answers. Randomize the first six choices; anchor Another method and None of these. None of these is exclusive. Allow 100 characters for Another method.

Q4. What was the outcome?

The whole shift was covered by one person; The shift was split between people; Only part of the shift was covered; The shift remained unfilled; The shift was cancelled; I cannot remember.

Programming: Single answer, fixed order. Do not exclude managers whose attempt failed.

Q5. Which difficulties did you encounter?

Could not tell who was available; Waited for replies; Unsure who had the required skills; Lost track of who had accepted; Approval took too long; Concerned about sharing personal contact details; Another difficulty [text]; None of these.

Programming: Multiple answers. Randomize substantive choices; anchor Another difficulty and None of these at the end. None of these is exclusive. Show a 100-character text field for Another difficulty.

Q6. Which difficulties mattered most on this occasion?

Pipe the difficulties selected at Q5, in their previously displayed order.

Programming: Ask if Q5 has three or more difficulties; select up to two. Carry one or two selections forward automatically. Skip Q7 if Q5 is None of these.

Q7. How did [selected difficulty] affect the outcome?

[Optional written response]

Programming: Repeat for each selected or carried difficulty, maximum two loops. Optional text, up to 300 characters. Permit a blank answer. Do not request names, contact details or account numbers.

Q8. How easy or difficult was it to keep track of who had agreed to work?

1 Very difficult; 2 Difficult; 3 Somewhat difficult; 4 Neither difficult nor easy; 5 Somewhat easy; 6 Easy; 7 Very easy. Separate option: No one agreed to work.

Programming: Single answer. Keep this scale in the displayed order; show every verbal label. Do not randomize scale points. The separate option must not be coded as a low ease score.

Service idea

Show the following concept on its own screen. Do not add logos, testimonials or success claims. Allow the respondent to reopen the description while answering Q9 to Q16.

ShiftHarbor Cover would let a manager send an open shift to selected eligible team members. Recipients could accept or decline through a private link. The manager would see responses in one place and approve the final assignment. The service would not automatically change payroll or guarantee that a shift is filled. Assume it costs $29 per location per month, with no per-message fee.

Q9. What is your first reaction to this idea?

[Optional written response]

Programming: Optional text, up to 300 characters. Permit a blank answer. Do not request names, contact details or account numbers. Ask before showing benefit or concern lists.

Q10. How easy or difficult was it to understand how the service would work?

1 Very difficult; 2 Difficult; 3 Somewhat difficult; 4 Neither difficult nor easy; 5 Somewhat easy; 6 Easy; 7 Very easy. Separate option: I did not read enough to answer.

Programming: Single answer. Keep this scale in the displayed order; show every verbal label. Do not randomize scale points.

Q11. Which parts, if any, would be useful in your workplace?

Inviting selected eligible staff; Accept or decline through a private link; Seeing responses in one place; Manager approval before assignment; Another useful part [text]; None of these.

Programming: Multiple answers. Randomize the first four choices; anchor the final two. None of these is exclusive. Another useful part opens 100-character text.

Q12. Which concerns, if any, would you have?

Staff might miss the link; Eligibility information could be wrong; It would duplicate another tool; Staff might feel pressured to accept; The price would be too high; Another concern [text]; None of these.

Programming: Multiple answers. Randomize the first five choices; anchor the last two. None of these is exclusive. Do not preselect a concern.

Q13. At $29 per location per month, how likely would your workplace be to try this service?

1 Very unlikely; 2 Unlikely; 3 Somewhat unlikely; 4 Neither likely nor unlikely; 5 Somewhat likely; 6 Likely; 7 Very likely. Separate option: I do not have enough information to judge.

Programming: Single answer. Keep this scale in the displayed order; show every verbal label. Do not randomize scale points. Retain the stated price. Do not describe hypothetical interest as a purchase commitment.

Q14. What would most influence that decision?

[Optional written response]

Programming: Optional text, up to 300 characters. Permit a blank answer. Do not request names, contact details or account numbers. Ask regardless of the Q13 scale answer or separate option.

Q15. Who would need to approve trying a service like this?

Me alone; Me together with someone else; Someone else without me; I do not know.

Programming: Single answer, fixed order. If Someone else or I do not know, skip Q16.

Q16. What evidence would you need before approving a trial?

A demonstration with our own workflow; A short test with one team; Information about data handling; A cost comparison; References from another workplace; Another type of evidence [text]; None of these.

Programming: Ask only for the first two Q15 answers. Multiple answers; randomize the first five choices. Anchor the last two; None of these is exclusive.

Workplace classification

Q17. Approximately how many people work at your location?

1 to 9; 10 to 24; 25 to 49; 50 to 99; 100 or more; Prefer not to say.

Programming: Single answer, fixed ordinal order. Ask after the concept evaluation.

Q18. Which type of workplace do you manage or support?

Retail; Food or hospitality; Warehousing or distribution; Care or support services; Manufacturing; Another type [text]; Prefer not to say.

Programming: Single answer. Randomize the first five choices; anchor the last two. Do not collect the employer name.